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Negotiated Solution: A Prolonged Charade?

In a democratic country like India, where the government is elected by the people and is supposed to be answerable to them for its performance, at least at the time of the next elections, it cannot afford to be totally oblivious to its responsibility towards the very basic needs of its electorate. These include maintenance of law and order, and peace and harmony, which in turn are so very essential for agricultural, industrial and economic progress.

The Central government needed to be seen to be doing something about the unrest in Punjab. Indira Gandhi thus expressed an interest in finding a negotiated solution to the Punjab problem. Simultaneously, she also let senior officials concerned know that if the situation called for it she would not hesitate to use the elite commando unit, the Special Frontier Force (SFF), to pick up Bhindranwale from the Golden Temple complex and place him in confinement.

Indira Gandhi and her government soon started making repeated and concerted efforts to enter into and pursue negotiations with the moderate Akali leadership led by Sant Harchand Singh Longowal. But in reality the prolonged exercise was a charade, as each round (P.C. Alexander said there were a total of twenty-six rounds) of negotiation ended without producing any results, with the 'un-cooperative', 'adamant', 'incapable' or 'powerless' moderate Akali leadership being usually blamed for its failure.